FOGGS | Foundation for Global Governance and Sustainability

RE-OPEN THE GLOBAL GOVERNANCE DOORS

THROUGH A SERIES OF GLOBAL CONFERENCES TO ADVANCE THE SDGS AND THE 2030 AGENDA

Proposal submitted by FOGGS
to the UN Secretary-General's High-level Advisory Board on Effective Multilateralism (HLAB)
(12 August 2022)

- **Introduction – Why a series of global conferences**

In *Our Common Agenda* the UN Secretary-General called for the holding of two thematic global conferences – an education conference in 2022 and a follow-up to the 1995 Copenhagen Declaration on Social Development in 2025. These conferences will provide governments and other participants with an opportunity to advance two important items on the global agenda. The Secretary-General's call also offers an opportunity to reflect strategically on the overall role of global conferences and the multiple benefits they generate, if correctly organized.

In addition to enlivening the international response to key challenges, notably those addressed through the SDGs, global conferences can set in motion greater citizen participation and revive the fortunes of the UN, increasing its convening / leadership role and thus its legitimacy. At the moment, even in the eyes of the informed public, the UN has become increasingly disconnected from globally important problems. Fewer and fewer internationally oriented civil society organizations and social movements look to the UN system to provide a platform to address their central concerns. It is time to reverse this dynamic and show that the UN system is willing to re-open its doors to global action, putting to good use the lessons learnt from the conferences of the 1990s.

- **Past experience – The conferences of the 1990s**

What were these precedent-setting "conferences of the '90s"? The list starts with the 1990 conference on and led by the Least Developed Countries in Paris. It was followed with the groundbreaking 1992 Rio Conference on Environment and Development ('Earth Summit') and the signing of three global conventions, on climate change, desertification and biodiversity . A year later (1993) was a conference on human rights in Vienna, which called for the ratification of the Convention on the Rights of the Child and for a High Commissioner for Human Rights. The following year (1994) the Cairo Conference on Population and Development enlarged the scope of population policies to include social development beyond family planning. In 1995 there was both the Copenhagen Social Development Conference, as mentioned above, and the Beijing Fourth Women's Conference, which is a well-regarded milestone in the internationalization of the women's movement. The end of this series of conferences was the Financing for Development Conference in Monterrey, Mexico, in 2002, which endeavoured to change the dynamics between the Bretton Woods Institutions, the WTO, ECOSOC and UNCTAD.

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Each of the above conferences provided an opportunity for tens of thousands of people to express their views on a major global issue of importance to them and to feel, whatever the actual outcome of a 5 - 10 day event, that they were part of the solution via the UN. These people and the organizations they represented had a unique opportunity to engage on their issue with governments from around the world, and sometimes used the international UN platform to appeal to their own government to take a better position on a key issue. These large gatherings also facilitated international networking among civil society organizations and social movements from different geographic regions and attracted significant press coverage of the UN and its work.

In a way, the conferences of the 1990s were too successful in defining new global issues and putting governments on the spot for urgent action. The backlash reflected itself in the 2000s widespread attitude among mainly Northern delegations, both OECD and non-OECD, that there should be no new conferences, no new organizations. In fighting back to re-gain their loss of traditional leadership, those states caused the UN itself to suffer a loss of leadership and a loss of engagement from hundreds of thousands of informed global activists. This loss can be rectified and the UN system can again be seen as a leading social and political force that is relevant to the lives of people.

- **Time to re-open the global governance doors through a series of global conferences**

The term "conferences of the '90s" was in fact given retrospectively to all the aforementioned, separately convened meetings. FOGGS' proposal is that the international community learn from this experience. The 2023 Summit for the Future (SOTF) should approve a plan for a series of international conferences over the next decade, as part of re-opening the UN system to global public participation. The SOTF could confirm the scope and timing of the individual conferences to make the collection of events coherent and announce the important message to the wider international non-state communities that the United Nations welcomes them back into the effort of building a more effective and inclusive multilateralism.

By deciding to host a series of global conferences in the 2020s and 2030s, the UN system would:

- Bring a wide range of people from all of the world's regions together to engage with governments on pressing issues of the day under the United Nations umbrella;
- Invite those most affected by a given crisis or a systemic exclusion to develop their own collective views on how the global community should respond to the crisis or what steps to take to overcome marginalization;
- Convene multilaterally-led conferences with outcome documents that include clear government commitments to implementation;
- Re-establish that UN system bodies should be the place where norm development, policy making and organizational leadership on contemporary global crises come together; and
- Devise a system of advisory assemblies, where key non-state actors work together, first within their own constituency to formulate their group views and then share those views with both governments and other major non-state global actors.[1]

[1] See also separate FOGGS proposal on a Global Resilience Council - https://www.foggs.org/grc-global-resilience-council/ - which has also been submitted to the HLAB.

- **Establishing the rules and procedures for the new global conferences**

The 2023 Summit of the Future could endorse a package of *common conference rules and procedures*, which could include:

- Each of these conferences, or at least one preparatory meeting of each, should be held outside major UN host cities;[2]
- Each conference and its secretariat should be co-hosted by an appropriate intergovernmental body of the central UN and a relevant specialized agency of the UN system;
- The convenors and negotiators at these conferences should be governments, not corporate sponsors or multistakeholder groups;[3]
- Non-state actors should be offered virtual and physical space and time to function as advisory assemblies of diverse constituencies, organizing their respective constituency's key messages and conveying them to the government negotiators, other constituencies and the broader public. The rules should address various asymmetries in power between participating constituency groups and establish meaningful conflict of interest rules and practices;
- Advance distribution of documents under negotiation in each conference, with government and regional organization proposals in brackets, followed by the relevant proposals put forward by the constituency assemblies of non-state actors;
- The intergovernmental outcome document should include specific measures and financial commitments by governments for implementation, as well as commitments made by non-state actors and any strong diverging views the latter might have.

This proposal should be understood in conjunction with the recommendation for *constituency assemblies* in the FOGGS proposal for a Global Resilience Council (GRC) that is being submitted to the HLAB separately. As elaborated in the GRC proposal, multidimensional mega-crises inherently involve not only states but also diverse communities of non-state actors, which could be institutionalized as advisory assemblies. Each advisory assembly would be expected to define the respective constituency's response to each specific mega-crisis, advise the GRC in its deliberations, and see to it that its members do their part in implementing the GRC decisions for effectively dealing with the crisis. Each advisory assembly would also be expected to evaluate the views of the other advisory assemblies and dialogue with them on causes, impacts and solutions.

- **Potential topics for the new global conferences**

Given the current public disillusionment with the UN system, there is no shortage of topics that could – and should – be considered for conferences in the 2020s and 2030s. The selection of conference themes should be well-grounded and jointly scheduled over the coming ten to fifteen years to re-welcome citizens from around the world to global governance.

[2] Geneva, Nairobi, New York, Vienna, Washington.

[3] Unlike the OCA, which envisages conferences under multistakeholder leadership, this proposal to reinvigorate the UN system firmly places all these gatherings under multilateral leadership.

Among *potential conference topics* are (in square brackets some relevant SDGs; SDG17 on partnerships implied in all cases):

- **Global Youth**, a conference where youth is both the subject of the conference and the lead conveners; [SDGs 4, 5, 8, 16]
- **Planetary Management**, to bring together issues of climate, biodiversity, pollution, soil and water resources, raw materials and other interconnected but separately treated aspects of human interaction with planet Earth; [SDGs 13, 14, 15]
- **Outer Space and the Atmosphere**, as decisions about these key global commons, the new frontier of humanity, should not be left to militaries and organizations with significant commercial interests; [SGD 16]
- **Internet Governance**, to re-energize the internet governance discussion under government and citizen leadership, not de facto managed through commercial multistakeholderism; [SDGs 4, 8, 9, 10, 16]
- **Caregivers Worldwide**, to define the role, recognize the status and propose measures to reward accordingly those – mostly women – who actively provide care to people within families and in the broader society; [SDGs 3, 5, 8, 10, 16]
- **Economic Governance and Inequality**, to review the functioning of the global financial system, with respect to the development needs of developing countries but also the increasing economic inequalities between and within countries that threaten human development and peace; [SDGs 10, 16]
- **Celebrating Human Diversity**, to give visibility to and celebrate the broad diversity that exists within humanity (e.g. in terms of cultures, religions, languages, social systems, gender identities, food / cuisines) and to show how this diversity is the key to human adaptability and resilience; [SDGs 5, 10, 16, 17]
- **Peace Without Guns**, to highlight the best practices of citizen and bottom-up peacebuilding, peacemaking and peace governance, and to define ways in which the international community can creatively backstop these initiatives. [SDG 16]

As explained earlier, such a planned sequence of intergovernmental conferences under UN auspices could boost the legitimacy of the UN and significantly expand the engagement of people from around the world in global governance, directly through the thousands that would attend and indirectly for the billions who would be represented and kept informed.

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